

Tuning in: Psychedelics and music

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BOOK REVIEW



Gelberg, Steven J. (2025). *Tuning In: Experiencing Music in Psychedelic States*. Albany, NY: State University of New York Press.

Tuning In can be considered a pioneering study on the role of music in psychedelic states, exploring how these experiences can expand our aesthetic perception, deepen our listening, and enrich musical appreciation. The work skillfully blends the author's personal narrative with academic research and interviews with musicians, psychologists, and mystics, creating a beautifully articulated testimony on the intersection between sound and non-ordinary states of consciousness.

Steven J. Gelberg is an American author and scholar whose personal and intellectual journey has spanned spirituality, religious criticism, music, and psychedelia. Gelberg was a member of ISKCON (International Society for Krishna Consciousness) from 1970 to 1987, during which time he adopted the spiritual name Subhananda Das. During those 17 years, he served in a variety of roles within the organization, including writer, editor, and director of interfaith relations. Gelberg earned a Master of Theological Studies from Harvard Divinity School in 1990. Gelberg is the author and editor of several works that reflect his spiritual and intellectual journey, including *Hare Krishna*, *Hare Krishna: Five Distinguished Scholars on the Krishna Movement in the West* (1983), a collection of interviews with scholars on the Hare Krishna movement, *India in a Mind's Eye: Travels and Ruminations of an Ambivalent Pilgrim* an account of his travels to India and reflections on his spiritual experience, and essays such as *On Leaving ISKCON* and *Oh, The Things I Learned!* in which he shares his experiences and critiques of the Hare Krishna movement. In *Turning In* Gelberg guides the reader through a journey that begins with his own experience with music and psychedelics and expands into a broader and more philosophical investigation. Music, as he affirms, acts as a profound conduit during psychedelic sessions—a mediator between the conscious and unconscious, the sensory and the spiritual. Throughout the book, he suggests various musical selections, divided by specific themes, with direct links to Spotify playlists. These carefully curated lists function as a living sonic library, rich in variety and with enormous potential to catalyze mystical experiences.

In recent decades, we have seen growing interest in using music as a therapeutic tool in psychedelic contexts. Furthermore, as the author points out, music has been recognized as a foundational element of deep psychedelic journeys since the 1950s. The book thus fills a significant gap by offering practical guidance and specific musical suggestions that can be used by therapists and practitioners alike.

The expanding field of psychedelic research in the West has reconfigured our understanding of spirituality, pointing toward experiences that transcend the boundaries of rationality. When paired with music, this expansion reaches new heights: this combination opens doors to subtle discoveries that are difficult to express in ordinary language but resonate with archetypal and emotional truth.

According to Gelberg, during psychedelic sessions, music can evoke love, transporting the listener to other realms of experience, stirring deep emotions, offering comfort, and inspiring profound transformation. Its therapeutic power lies especially in its paradoxical nature: while it can provide emotional anchoring, it simultaneously propels consciousness toward expansion. Participant-centered musical selection and openness to deep listening are directly associated with both immediate and long-term positive outcomes.

Gelberg argues that music contributes to the psychedelic experience in several ways: it can facilitate and energize the journey's onset, provide structure and containment, touch the emotional and spiritual core of the individual, serve as a mirror of the unconscious, create imaginal worlds of beauty and transcendence, and transmit profound meaning.

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In altered states, aesthetic sensitivity becomes heightened—and this includes a transformed way of listening to music. Familiar sounds are perceived in entirely new ways, and melodies once considered ordinary can become portals to revelatory experiences. Listening becomes embodied, immersive, and at times even visual, thanks to synesthesia or intensified mental imagery.

The author organizes a range of Spotify playlists, divided into themes that reflect emotional or intentional states. Among them:

- **Classical and neoclassical music for psychedelic states:** “Classical Music for Psychedelic States,” “Neo-classical for Psychonauts.”
- **Emotional and spiritual qualities:** “Positive Mood,” “Peace, Serenity,” “Compassion, Love, Benevolence, Tenderness,” “Introspection, Reflection, Nostalgia,” “Sweet Sorrow,” “Hoping, Longing, Yearning.”
- **Exploration and transcendence:** “Fantastic Journeys, Mystical Trips,” “Christian Mystical Music,” “Women Composers.”
- **Ambient and evocative music:** “Mycelium Dawn,” “Kaleidoscopic Mind,” “Utopian Moon Garden,”

“Ethereal Dreams,” “Samadhi,” “Electric Dreams,” “A Sacred Mind,” “Unconditional Love,” “Spacetime Curvature,” among others.

- **World music and the collective unconscious:** “World Music,” “Tribal, Trance, Drums, Shamanic, Ayahuasca,” “Earth Women Sing,” “Indian Classical Music,” “Hindu Prayers, Meditations, Devotions,” “Tamboura Drones,” “Psychedelica Indica.”
- **Sound alternatives to music:** “The Music of Nature,” “White Noise,” and other soundscapes that include natural sounds, often used in electronic music geared toward psychedelic experiences.

It’s worth emphasizing that *Tuning In* is not intended as a technical guide or a general introduction to the therapeutic use of psychedelics. Its focus is more sensitive and poetic: it is an inquiry into the musical experience within expanded states of consciousness. As the author himself explains, his main motivation was the image of a single person—anywhere in the world—immersed in a psychedelic journey, deeply attuned to one of the musical pieces from these recommended playlists, and surrendered to ecstasy, introspection, or wonder. That person, he tells us, could very well be you.